

Editorial

Questioning The Net

IN INTERNET TIME, the Wikipedia-Siegenthaler controversy is already old. But I haven't stopped thinking about the core issue—that of the veracity of the information we find on the Net.

For those of you who missed the story, some joker posted a Wikipedia entry suggesting that John Siegenthaler Sr.—an American journalist, writer, and political figure—had a role in the assassinations of both JFK and Robert F Kennedy. Sure, Wikipedia tightened its editorial process after the incident, but what about the rest of the information out there?

It's time to do some soul-searching. How much of what you find on the Net has been validated and authenticated by either an expert, a government, or any sort of responsible body? Not much.

Actually, it's not entirely about taking for truth the stuff you find online. It's as much about the Net forming your opinions for you. Absolutely anyone can influence anyone else on the Weird Wild Web—one post, one blog, one comment can do it. And who isn't influenced—subliminally or otherwise—by a site's look and feel? Talking about opinions, the views expressed on the Web are almost entirely those of folks on the connected side of the digital divide. And that only increases the disconnect.

I'm mourning the death of scholarship. "Research" for many students has been reduced to the compilation of online "facts" and figures. Students even cite Web sites as their source of information. And then there's the issue of their quoted site having lifted its content from elsewhere on the dub-dub-dub!

Now think plagiarism, and how easy it is to present someone else's research as one's own. Online "research" even fetches degrees for some students. What students don't realise is that in the bargain, their cognitive growth and the ability to think beyond the obvious is being stunted.

Beyond students, even the media sometimes does not question content on the Internet, and uses it for background information on people, issues, political parties, and so on.

I chanced upon this bit of news at theinquirer.net: someone in a Honolulu paper was recently fired for having borrowed too much from Wikipedia. But hey, I'm now thinking, can I trust this piece of online news?

There are real dangers associated with this "Web as Gospel Truth" phenomenon—people self-med-



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icate based on online info. In controversial topics such as religion and history, people quote people, who quoted people, who... you get the idea. In the process, controversies flare out of proportion.

What's really needed is a mechanism—something along the lines of our cover story—that regulates and authenticates all that goes on the Net. Which is very difficult, but not impossible. What is achievable now is the creation of "certified URLs"—sites regularly checked and monitored for content by peers and competitors. The ICANN or another regulatory body could then declare these sites as certified, credible sources of information.

I'd like to see a VVV—a Verified Valuable Vault of information out there.

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